

Stress

Whether it's related to exams or frustration with family, everyone feels stressed sometimes. Stress can be a positive thing, motivating teens to work well under pressure, but too much of it can have a harmful effect on a person's emotional and physical health.

SEE ALSO

◀ 82–83 Positive mental health

◀ 86–87 Confidence and self-esteem

◀ 90–91 Resilience

Anxiety and depression

94–95 ▶

Fight or flight

When the body feels stress, it goes into “fight or flight” mode, releasing a mixture of hormones that prepares the body for action. These hormones increase energy and divert blood away from the brain and into the muscles. This stress response works well when a human's life is in danger, but it's less helpful when it's triggered for something that isn't life-threatening, such as taking an exam.



△ Fight

The “fight” mechanism prepares the brain and body to defend itself.



△ Flight

The “flight” mechanism leads a person to look for a way to escape the situation.

Triggers

A “trigger” is anything that is the initial cause of stressful feelings. While most triggers are external—meaning they are in response to things happening outside the person, such as exams or difficult family events—some are internal, resulting from pressures that people put on themselves.

▽ Identifying triggers

There are many different things that can cause teens to feel stressed.



TEEN HINTS

Figuring out stress

Sometimes it can be hard to work out what it is that's causing stress—especially if everything seems to be happening at once. Take time to think through and write down what is bothering you. This could give you ideas about the practical changes you could make to help you manage stressful feelings.

GOOD TO KNOW

Good and bad stress

Stress can sometimes be very useful, as it motivates people to keep working under pressure and energizes them to complete tasks they care about. But if it becomes overwhelming, stress can limit a person's ability to function effectively. When you're feeling stressed, try to use it as motivation to tackle a challenge, but if things start to seem unmanageable, seek support.